Beth Rudden

Business and technology executive
Founder and CEO, Bast AI | IBM Distinguished Engineer | Board trustee

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Executive Profile

I build and lead teams that turn complex problems into systems people can understand, trust, and use. My background in anthropology and engineering shapes how I lead: understand the people and the mission, make the problem clear, and build the organization capable of solving it. I connect technical depth with business judgment to help institutions serve people better.

Founder and CEO of Bast AI, IBM Distinguished Engineer (appointed 2016), and board trustee. My work brings together the realities of running a business and the realities of how people learn, make decisions, and care for one another.

The work in five outcomes

- Led IBM's workforce transformation, upskilling and reskilling 23,000 people in 16 months.
- Created the data-science profession through which more than 10,000 data scientists have been certified globally.
- Owned and grew two P&Ls by double digits, helping establish the foundation for AI at IBM.
- Created technology spanning 27 issued IBM patents and five Bast patents.
- Built Bast over four years, securing $1.5M in revenue and $750K in investment.

Professional Experience

Founder and CEO, Bast AI · October 2022-present

Founded Bast to build explainable AI for healthcare and other regulated institutions. Lead engineers and domain experts, giving each the authority to do their best work and setting the standards that connect them. Own client outcomes from scoping through production.

We build the knowledge layer underneath AI, structuring domain expertise so answers can be traced to evidence and unresolved terms are flagged. From BastCare to institutional deployments, our work helps people understand care and access expert knowledge in difficult environments.

Led Bast's transition to agentic delivery, with human review of every change. Build the teams, partnerships, and evaluation practices needed to deliver dependable systems and sustain the business.

Bast architecture provides an AI system that uses 70-85% fewer tokens per interaction versus standard retrieval-augmented generation.

IBM business and technical leadership · 23 years

Owned and grew the Content Intelligence and AI at Scale businesses, carrying responsibility for their P&Ls and leading teams to deliver business results. Established the Trustworthy AI Center of Excellence and recruited its leadership.

As Chief Data Officer for IBM's services division, led workforce transformation through upskilling and reskilling. Used the urgency of enterprise change to help people move into new kinds of work, and directed large-scale endpoint remediation to address security and data-protection requirements.

Created and secured The Open Group accreditation for the data-science profession, building the skills and professional standards needed to deliver AI at global scale.

Board & Advisory

Board of Trustees, Denver Museum of Nature & Science

Board of Trustees, Maryville University

Advisory Board, Center for Advancing Safety of Machine Intelligence (CASMI), Northwestern University

Regulating AI - Expert

Cognitive World Think Tank Member

Conference Host, Enterprise AI World at KMWorld (2024, 2025)

Patents, Publications & Open Technical Assets

27 issued IBM patents and five Bast patents, spanning work in AI, natural language, knowledge systems, and data protection. Patent records are commonly indexed under Mary E. Rudden. Select patents and open technical assets were contributed to open-source ecosystems, including the Linux Foundation.

Open Technical Assets

IBM Data Science - Best Practices: open-source production-readiness playbook for data scientists and ML engineers, covering versioning, scalability, monitoring, engineering, testing, quality measurement, model training, deployment, automation, sizing, and security.

Bast AI

Five Bast patents covering the core ontology engine and explainable AI architecture.

Selected IBM-Era Patents

Ontology-driven Feature Engineering in Statistical Predictions

Hyperplane Optimization in High Dimensional Ontology

Generative Learning Paths for Autonomous Upskilling

Representation of Distributional Similarity in Semantic Graphs

Violation and Exception Life Cycle Management via Blockchain

Method to Identify and Prevent Privacy Violations in Consumer Devices

Education & Credentials

MA Anthropology - University of Denver (1998)

BA Classical Archaeology (Greek and Latin) - Florida State University (1996)

IBM Appointments

Distinguished Engineer - IBM (appointed 2016)

Senior Technical Staff Member (STSM) - IBM (appointed 2012)

IBM Master Inventor (2019)

Professional Certifications

Distinguished Data Scientist - Professional Certification, The Open Group (2024)
Recognized through the data-science profession Beth created and secured accreditation for through The Open Group in 2018

L3 Thought Leader Certified Data Scientist, The Open Group (2018; renewed 2022 and 2024)

Books

AI for the Rest of Us (co-author) - Nominated #1 book to read in 2024 by Constellation Research

Julian Steward and the Great Basin (co-author and editor)

Writing & Expert Contributions

Data is a belonging of human experience - Ground Truth **(October 4, 2026)**

Field notes, early October 2026 - Ground Truth **(October 3, 2026)**

What Do People Do All Day - with AI? - Ground Truth **(October 2, 2026)**

It's time to focus on the water - Ground Truth **(September 22, 2026)**

One Man Cannot Hold the Future - Ground Truth **(September 12, 2026)**

AI Will Become Ubiquitous. Human Judgment Will Not. - Ground Truth **(July 23, 2026)**

Moving From Adoption to Adaptation for Explainable AI - Enterprise AI World · Crossing the AI Chasm **(June 23, 2026)**

Why Data Products Break the Binary - Enterprise AI World · Crossing the AI Chasm **(March 19, 2026)**

The Users We Didn't Plan For - Enterprise AI World · Crossing the AI Chasm **(January 9, 2026)**

"7 Ways to Spot Someone Who Thinks the AI Understands Them" - most-read essay on Beth's Substack, 63K views **(2026)**

Cognitive World - Writer and Expert Contributor

VentureBeat - Writer and Expert Contributor

Enterprise AI World - "Crossing the AI Chasm" featured column

Substack

Medium

Google Scholar - Publications

Selected Podcasts & Interviews

Explainable AI with Beth Rudden CEO at Bast AI - Trending in Education · Mike Palmer **(June 23, 2026)**

Human Wisdom and Better Leadership with Beth Rudden - Authentic Ewe · Penelope Aiken **(April 11, 2026)**

Your data isn't exhaust. It's a belonging. - Untangled · Charley Johnson **(March 28, 2026)**

Your AI Is Your Mirror, Not Your Oracle: How Heuristics Hijack Your Thinking - Alistair Langer · Episode 72 **(January 8, 2026)**

Masters of Scale Strategy Sessions - with Reid Hoffman and Rana el Kaliouby

Redefining AI Ethics: The Key Role of Explainability - DataStax Podcast

Artificiality Institute - Conversation **(2025)**

Awards & Recognition

Empressa AI25 - Named one of 25 Women Setting the Standard for Leadership in AI **(2026)**

WOW3 Unstoppable - Most Inspirational Women of Web3 and AI **(2025)**

Distinguished Data Scientist - Professional Certification, The Open Group **(2024)**

Bast AI awarded OEDIT Early-Stage Capital and Retention Grant **(2024)**

AI for the Rest of Us - Nominated #1 book to read in 2024 by Constellation Research

100 Most Brilliant Leaders in AI Ethics **(2023)**

IBM Master Inventor **(2019)**

Lifetime Achievement Award, IBM Academy of Technology

Policy & Public Accountability

Testified before the Colorado Senate Judiciary Committee on SB24-205, Colorado's landmark AI consumer protection act

Panelist alongside Colorado AG Phil Weiser at Silicon Flatirons on the regulatory future of AI

Speaker at ISP Symposium, Denver Museum of Nature & Science, with Congressman Joe Neguse on science communication ethics **(2023)**

Selected Keynotes & Public Leadership

September 25, 2026 | Who Did the Work? - WeAreDevelopers World Congress North America | Developing talent and sustaining human accountability as AI changes work

2026 | The Cynefin Exploratory - Eagle | One of three Eagles with Dave Snowden and Delia McCabe

2026 | EarthX - Speaker

2025 | Concordia Live | Gen. David Petraeus (Ret.) and Arvind Krishna in attendance

2025 | Denver Council on Foreign Relations - Keynote | Followed by the Dean of the Korbel School, the Ambassador of the Middle East, and Representative of Taiwan

2024 | SXSW EDU - AI's Leap: Shaping Tailored Learning

2024 | Colorado Senate Judiciary Committee - SB24-205 | Testimony on Colorado's landmark AI consumer protection act

2023 | ISP Symposium, Denver Museum of Nature & Science | With Congressman Joe Neguse - ethics of science communication

2023 | The Salzburg Dialogue (Austria)

2023 | Global Female Leaders Economic Forum (Berlin)

Upcoming Speaking

Explainability Is Infrastructure, Not a Feature - Scheduled · Enterprise AI World 2026 **(November 18, 2026)**

Closing Keynote: Knowledge Sharing, AI, & Enterprise Intelligence for Enterprise Success - Scheduled · Enterprise AI World 2026 **(November 19, 2026)**